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room to cajole and pressure political actors. However, if there is something other than the polarisation within the polity that the current results indicate, it is that the Establishment cannot guarantee any scenarios any more, that there are limits to its powers to influence democratic politics and that it has become increasingly difficult to manipulate elections. Some of this was apparent to the Establishment from the beginning, which is why elections were delayed in the first place beyond the constitutionally mandated period of three months from the dissolution of the last assemblies.

Given Pakistan's precarious economic situation, the Establishment also recognises that political stability is the foremost prerequisite for any economic recovery and that without a focus on the economy, even its own position as an institution may be endangered. But as the public clamour for the military to dissociate itself from politics altogether gathers momentum—most political parties stung by the election results are calling for this right now—the challenge for army chief Gen. Asim Munir will be to balance this demand with the military's continued belief in itself as the ultimate saviour of Pakistan and arbiter of the country's national interests. ■

